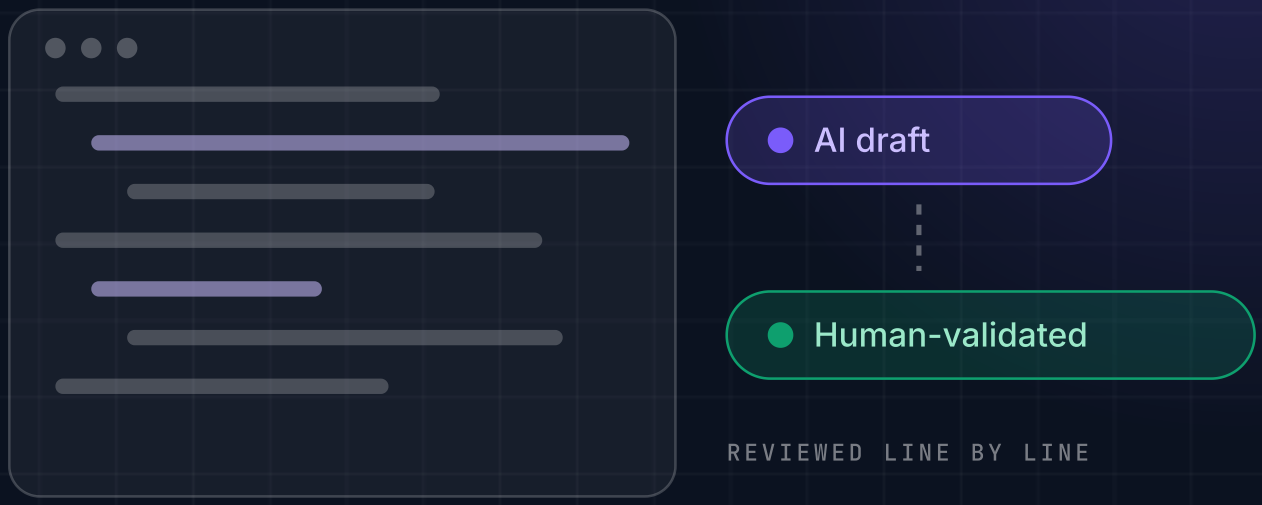
12-MINUTE READ · 1 CHECKLIST

AI-built, *human-signed.*

A buyer's guide to software made with AI in 2026: what really speeds up, what quietly breaks, and the 10-point sign-off checklist to demand.



THE NEW DEAL

Your next developer will use AI. *That's not the question.*

Almost every developer now writes code with AI assistants. That's good news for you: software can be cheaper and faster to make than ever. But "the AI wrote it" is not a quality standard. The question that matters is simple: **who checks it, and how?**

84%

of developers use or plan to use AI tools in their work, up from 76% a year earlier.

STACK OVERFLOW DEVELOPER SURVEY 2025 [1]

46%

of developers actively distrust the accuracy of AI tools' output. Only 33% trust it; 3% "highly" trust it.

STACK OVERFLOW DEVELOPER SURVEY 2025 [1]

45%

of the time, AI models picked the insecure way to write code when a secure way existed, across 80 tasks and 100+ models.

VERACODE GENAI CODE SECURITY REPORT 2025 [2]

19%

slower: experienced developers took longer with AI on their own projects, while believing they were about 20% faster.

METR RANDOMIZED TRIAL, 2025 [3]

Read those numbers together and a picture appears. AI is everywhere, the people who use it most don't fully trust it, it makes security mistakes at a worrying rate, and it can even make people feel faster than they are. None of this means "avoid AI". It means **AI output is a first draft, and a first draft needs an editor.**

Your brief → AI draft → Human-validated → You test and accept

The shape of a healthy AI-era project: the machine accelerates, a person who is accountable decides, and you have the last word.

STRENGTHS AND BLIND SPOTS

What AI is great at, *and where it trips.*

As a buyer, you don't need to know how AI writes code. You need to know which parts of your project it speeds up, and which parts still need an experienced human's full attention.

GREAT AT

- ✓ **First drafts** of screens, forms and admin pages.
- ✓ **Repetitive code** every app needs: sign-in, lists, filters, exports.
- ✓ **Tests**: writing many checks quickly, so more gets tested.
- ✓ **Data clean-up** scripts for moving your spreadsheet into the new app.
- ✓ **Documentation** and plain-language summaries of what changed.
- ✓ **Trying three designs** in the time one used to take.
- ✓ **Translation** of the interface into French and other languages, as a draft for a person to review.

TRIPS ON

- ✗ **Your business rules.** It doesn't know that refunds over $200 need a manager unless someone tells it, and checks.
- ✗ **Security in context.** Who is allowed to see what is easy to get subtly wrong.
- ✗ **Large existing systems** full of history and unwritten knowledge.
- ✗ **Being confidently wrong.** Errors look as polished as correct code.
- ✗ **Made-up building blocks.** It sometimes suggests software packages that don't exist, which attackers can then register under that name [4].
- ✗ **Judgement calls**: trade-offs, priorities, what to leave out.

The rule of thumb

The more a piece of work depends on **pattern**, the more AI helps. The more it depends on **context** (your rules, your data, your customers, your risks), the more it needs an engineer who understands your business and is accountable for the result.

SPEED, HONESTLY

The speed-up is real. *Just not where you'd think.*

Typing code was never the slow part of software. Understanding the problem, making decisions, testing and fixing were. AI makes the typing nearly free, which shifts the work to **reviewing**. Teams that treat review as optional get speed now and pay for it later.

Where you'll feel it

- ✓ **Prototypes in days.** You can click something real before committing to the full build.
- ✓ **Cheaper changes.** "Can we try it the other way?" stops being a scary question.
- ✓ **More tests for the same budget**, if your vendor chooses to spend the saved time there.
- ✓ **Smaller projects make sense.** Tools that weren't worth building three years ago now are.

Where it can backfire

- ✗ **Stability.** Google's DORA research linked more AI adoption with an estimated 7.2% drop in delivery stability in 2024 [5].
- ✗ **Perception.** In METR's trial, developers felt faster while being slower [3]. Measure delivered results, not vibes.
- ✗ **Volume.** More code, faster, means more to maintain. Lines of code are a cost, not an asset.
- ✗ **Hidden dependencies.** Package suggestions that don't exist: at least 5.2% for commercial models, 21.7% for open-source ones, in one 2025 study [4].

> AI makes us faster. It should never make the decisions.
>
> The principle every AI-assisted project should be able to sign

What this means for your budget

Expect AI-assisted work to cost less and arrive sooner, especially for new, small and medium projects. Be wary of quotes that are dramatically cheaper with no word about review and testing: the saving usually comes out of exactly the steps that protect you.

THE SIGN-OFF CHECKLIST

10 things to demand *from any AI-assisted vendor.*

Put these in your contract or statement of work. A good team will say yes to all ten without blinking, because they already work this way.

01 **A named engineer is accountable for every change.** Not "the team", not "the AI". A person whose name is on it.

02 **Every change is reviewed line by line** before it reaches you. AI-written code gets the same review as human code, or more.

03 **Automated tests run on every change**, and you can see that they pass.

04 **Security is checked on purpose:** inputs validated, permissions enforced on the server (not just hidden buttons), passwords and keys never stored in the code.

05 **Every third-party package is verified** as real, maintained and necessary before it's added.

06 **Your data stays out of public AI tools.** Ask which AI services see your code or data, and under what terms. Real customer data should never be pasted into a chatbot.

07 **You test on a staging version** before anything goes live.

08 **Acceptance is written:** each of your acceptance criteria is marked passed or failed, by you.

09 **The code is readable by someone else:** documented, in your repository, in your name.

10 **There's a rollback plan:** if a release goes wrong, the previous version can be restored quickly.

Bonus for apps with AI features (chat, document reading, scoring): ask how wrong answers are caught, who reviews them, and how people are told when a decision about them was automated. In Québec that last part is a legal duty (see guide 05).

Green flags, *red flags.*

Ask these in your first call. You're not testing technical knowledge; you're listening for how they think about responsibility.

ASK	GREEN FLAG	RED FLAG
How do you use AI?	Specific: "for drafts, tests and migrations; an engineer reviews everything."	"AI does it all, that's why we're cheap." Or a flat denial in 2026.
Who reviews the code?	A named senior person, every change, before you see it.	"The AI checks itself." "We'll fix bugs as they come."
How do you test?	Automated tests plus testing against your acceptance criteria on real devices.	"We test manually at the end." "You can test it in production."
How is security handled?	Explains permissions, input checks, secrets, updates, in plain words.	"It's in the cloud, so it's secure."
Where does my data go?	Names the hosting provider and region, and the AI tools involved.	Vague, or "we'll paste it into ChatGPT to analyse it."
What if it doesn't work?	"We fix it within scope at no cost; you pay on acceptance."	"That would be a change request."
Who owns the result?	You: code, data, accounts, from day one.	"We host it on our account; you license it from us."
Can I see live work?	Links to running apps and someone who used them.	Only mock-ups and logos.

A good sign that's easy to miss

The best AI-era teams talk more about **review, tests and your business rules** than about which AI model they use. Models change every few months. Discipline doesn't.

DO IT YOURSELF?

"Can't I just build it *myself with AI?*"

Sometimes, yes. Chat-based app builders and AI assistants let non-developers make working tools in an afternoon, and that's wonderful. The question is what happens when that tool holds real data, real money or real customers.

YOU'RE BUILDING…	DIY WITH AI?	WHY
A personal tool, calculator or one-off script	GO FOR IT	Low stakes. If it breaks, you fix it or start over.
A clickable prototype to show your team or a developer	GO FOR IT	The best brief there is. It answers a hundred questions in five minutes.
An internal tool with no personal data, for a few colleagues	WITH CARE	Fine if someone owns it, backs it up and knows what happens when they leave.
Anything with logins, customers or personal information	GET A REVIEW	Permissions, privacy law and security are exactly where AI trips (page 3).
Anything that takes payments or drives money decisions	GET A REVIEW	One subtle bug is a financial loss, or a loss of customers' trust.

The smartest hybrid: prototype, then hand over

Build a rough version yourself with an AI tool to discover what you actually want. Then bring the prototype, plus the one-page brief from guide 02, to a professional team for a production version with proper logins, tests and privacy. You'll get a sharper quote, faster, because the guesswork is gone.

HOW WE DO IT

Five steps. *Two of them are yours.*

This is the method Addanapp uses on every request, from a small fix to a new product. Use it as a yardstick for any vendor, us included.

01 **Brief** YOU
Describe the outcome you need, in plain language. Screenshots and links welcome.

02 **Scope and fixed quote** HUMAN
An engineer writes acceptance criteria, flags risks and sends a fixed price with a delivery date. Nothing starts until you approve.

03 **Accelerated build** AI + ENGINEER
AI agents draft code, tests, migrations and documentation under an engineer's direction.

04 **Validation** HUMAN
Line-by-line review, security and privacy checks, and tests against your acceptance criteria on real devices.

05 **Accept, then pay** YOU
Try it on staging. Accept it, or ask for changes within scope at no extra cost. Then you're invoiced.

SOURCES

1. Stack Overflow, 2025 Developer Survey, AI section (about 49,000 respondents).
2. Veracode, "2025 GenAI Code Security Report", 30 July 2025: 80 coding tasks across more than 100 large language models; insecure option chosen in 45% of cases.
3. METR, "Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity", July 2025 (arXiv:2507.09089). 16 developers, 246 tasks; the authors caution against generalising beyond this setting.
4. J. Spracklen et al., "We Have a Package for You! A Comprehensive Analysis of Package Hallucinations by Code Generating LLMs", USENIX Security 2025. 16 models, 576,000 code samples.
5. Google Cloud DORA, "Accelerate State of DevOps Report 2024": estimated 1.5% lower throughput and 7.2% lower stability associated with increased AI adoption. Later DORA work reports throughput effects turning positive while stability concerns remain.

Addanapp

FROM THE TEAM AT ADDANAPP.COM

Know what you need? *We'll tell you what it costs.*

Addanapp is a Montréal software studio. We build business apps, portals, back-offices and integrations at AI speed, and a senior engineer signs off every change before it reaches you.

A fixed price first
Every request is quoted before work starts. Nothing starts until you approve.

No acceptance, no invoice
You test it on a staging version. If it doesn't meet the criteria, we fix it at no extra cost.

Human-validated
AI drafts, engineers decide. Line-by-line review, tests and security checks on every change.

You own everything
Code, data and accounts are yours from day one. Built with Law 25 and PIPEDA in mind.

Send a short brief (the template in guide 02 is perfect) and an engineer, not a salesperson, will reply with questions or a fixed quote.

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